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santa susana - Group to rally for area cleanup - Residents, activists to gather to mark the 60th anniversary of a nuclear meltdown at the site

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Residents will gather todayto mark the 60th anniversary of the partial nuclear meltdown at the Santa Susana Field Laboratory — and rally for a full cleanup of the site.

Residents will gather at 10 a.m. at Rancho Tapo Community Park, 3700 Avenida Simi in Simi Valley, at the pavilions near the ballpark. Community members and activists will paint rocks that will become part of a memorial to workers and community members affected by contamination at the site.

Melissa Bumstead, who said her young daughter has twice survived rare leukemia, said her community has been through “the silent devastation” since the meltdown. Bumstead launched a Change.org petition calling for a long-awaited cleanup signed by more than 650,000 people

“We were lied to, silenced and abandoned,” she said. “But instead of becoming bitter, we’re coming together to create art. We’re making a memorial to demonstrate our unity as we fight for the full cleanup.”

The site, nested above the Simi and San Fernando valleys, is a former nuclear and rocket engine testing facility, where on July 13, 1959, the Sodium Reactor Experiment experienced a partial nuclear meltdown.

In 2010, the parties responsible for cleaning up the site, the federal Department of Energy and NASA, signed an agreement to finish a full cleanup by 2017. Two years after its deadline, the cleanup has not started yet.

In March, a report from NASA’s Inspector General’s Office said the ambitious cleanup NASA

agreed to conduct under the terms of a now nine-year-old agreement is not achievable.

The inspector general’s report said it could cost NASA more than $500 million and take more than 25 years to clean up its portion of the contaminated area.

More than half a million people live within 10 miles of the site.

On Friday,Sen. Diane Feinstein and eight U.S. Congress members from California sent a letter to Energy Secretary Rick Perry, NASA Administrator Tim Bridenstine, and CalEPA Secretary Jared Blumenfeld urging compliance with agreements to fully clean up the site.

“We are deeply concerned that this required cleanup has not been completed and that the soil remediation has not even begun,” said the letter. “We are deeply concerned that DOE and NASA have publicly indicated that the agencies do not intend to comply with the longstanding SSFL clean-up agreement that DOE and NASA signed with the State of California.”

Today, attendees are expected to include:

• Michael Rose, a filmmaker who, as a UCLA student, was part of a team that discovered there had been a partial meltdown at SSFL.

• Representatives from the offices of Congress members Julia Brownley, Brad Sherman and Katie Hill.

• State Sen. Henry Stern.

• Assembly members Jesse Gabriel and Christy Smith.

• And members of the groups Physicians for Social Responsibility-Los Angeles, Rocketdyne Cleanup Coalition, and Parents vs. SSFL.

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